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Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles; A Study on Proclean Exegesis, with a Translation and Commentary of Proclus’ Treatise On Chaldean Philosophy

Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles

This volume examines the discussion of the Chaldean Oracles in the work of Proclus, as well as offering a

translation and commentary of Proclus' Treatise On Chaldean Philosophy. Spanu assesses whether Proclus' exegesis of the Chaldean Oracles can be used by modern research to better clarify the content of Chaldean doctrine or must instead be abandoned because it represents a substantial misinterpretation of originary Chaldean teachings.The volume is augmented by Proclus' Greek text, with English translation and commentary. Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles will be of interest to researchers working on Neoplatonism, Proclus and theurgy in the ancient world.

Nicola Spanu wrote a PhD thesis on Plotinus and his Gnostic disciples and took part in a postdoctoral project on Byzantine cosmology and its relation to Neoplatonism. He has worked as an independent researcher on his second academic publication, which has focused on Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles.

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Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles

A Study on Proclean Exegesis , with a Translation and Commentary of Proclus’ Treatise On Chaldean Philosophy

Nicola Spanu

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Introduction

0.1 The Chaldean Oracles and Proclus

The Chaldean Oracles (Χαλδαϊκά λόγια) have come down to us in highly fragmentary form. É. des Places’ edition

1 contains 227 fragments in hex-
ameter verse, of which 186 are authentic,
17 doubtful, while 24 consist in
a single word. The biggest number of them
has been discovered in Proclus'
Platonic commentaries. Damascius has also
preserved a considerable num-
ber of oracular sayings2 in his treatise
On the Principles, in his Commentary
on Plato's Parmenides3 and in that on the
Phaedo. 4 For both authors, the
Chaldean Oracles are a divine
revelation,5 and they refer to them with
the
objective of showing the agreement of
their own philosophy, of the doctrines
of Plato, Pythagoras and Orpheus as well
as of Greek traditional religion
with the Oracles (Λόγια) revealed by the
gods through their earthly represen-
tatives.6 These are called 'theurgists' (
θεουργοί), literally 'those who operate
on the gods', and were believed by Neo-
Platonists from Iamblichus onwards
to be mediators between man and the
gods.7 The connection between the
theurgists and the Chaldean Oracles is
shown by the fact that the authentic

fragment 153 des Places regards them as a spiritual elite capable of breaking the bonds that bind humanity to the world of becoming governed by inflexible Necessity.

With regard to the adjective ‘Chaldean’, this never appears in the extant fragments, while Proclus uses the expression ‘Chaldean Oracles’ (Χαλδαϊκά λόγια);8 he also seems to use the substantive ‘Chaldeans’ (Χαλδαῖοι) to refer to the authors of the Oracles,9 since in his Commentary on Plato’s Republic he mentions ‘the theurgists of the Chaldeans’ (οἱ παρὰ Χαλδαιοίς θεουργοὶ).10

We know that in Hellenistic culture the term ‘Chaldeans’ referred to those astrologers11 who wandered about the Roman Empire offering their services to rich clients.12 But, as fragment 107 des Places clearly shows, the Chaldean Oracles did not have a positive opinion of astrology, so we can assume that, if this designation accompanied the Λόγια since the time they were written

and was not a later addition, it was used to indicate their supposed Oriental provenance, of which the Neo-Platonists were generally aware, since they often referred to their authors as the ‘Assyrians’ or simply the ‘Barbarians’. 13

2 Introduction

With regard to the authorship and date of composition of the Chaldean Oracles, Suda’s Lexicon provides us with valuable information. It says that

Julian the Theurgist, son of Julian the Chaldean, 14 lived at the time of the emperor Marcus Aurelius (121–180 A.D.) and authored, in addition to works on Theurgy (Θεουργικά) and Telestics (Τελεστικά), 'Oracles in hexameter verse' (Λόγια δι' ἐπῶν). As we have seen, the term 'Oracles' (Λόγια) was the one used by Neo-Platonists to refer to the Chaldean Oracles.15 Scholarly consensus terminates at this point, since while H. Lewy 16 thought that the two Juliani, father and son, co-authored the Chaldean Oracles, H. D. Saffrey, on the basis of a strictly philological interpretation of Suda's text, came to the conclusion that Julian the Theurgist was their sole author. 17 There is no doubt that Saffrey's interpretation is much more philologically correct than Lewy's. However, a testimony from Psellus18 adduced by Saffrey himself19 – according to which Julian the Chaldean had recourse to the hieratic art to make both the gods and Plato's soul speak through his son (who

then really performed the role of oracle or prophet20 of this new divine revelation) – could be a sign that Julian the Chaldean's contribution to his son's endeavour to organize the Oracles of the gods in a coherent whole was not negligible; it is in this special sense that he could be said to have co-authored them. Probably the best choice in this regard is to follow des Places and consider the Chaldean Oracles as an anonymous text,21 or to speak of 'authors' of the Oracles in the plural as we have sometimes chosen to do, in order to show that collecting and putting in writing the Oracles of the gods must have been the result of a collective effort.

This is the tradition that Proclus, born in Constantinople in 412 from rich parents,22 came into contact with when he became disciple of Syrianus in Athens,23 which he preferred to Alexandria where for a time he had studied rhetoric and philosophy, because of lack of decent teachers of philosophy in

that city. 24 After the death of his master Syrianus,25 he became head of the Platonic Academy of Athens in around 437, 26 dying there in 485.27

In his Life of Proclus, Marinus, disciple and biographer of Proclus, reports that his master had studied the Chaldean Oracles almost by himself, since Syrianus had died before Proclus' disagreement with his fellow disciple Domninus whether their common master had to explain to them the Chaldean Oracles or the Orphic texts was resolved.28 As a consequence, when Syrianus died, Proclus had been taught by his master only the 'elements' (στοιχεῖα) of Chaldean wisdom.29 To obtain a deeper knowledge of the Oracles, which he regarded as a text of immense value comparable only to Plato's Timaeus,30 he made use of 'the best Commentaries on the God-given Oracles' (τὰ μέγιστα τῶν ὑπομνημάτων εἰς τὰ θεοπαράδοτα λόγια), namely Porphyry's and Iamblichus's ἐξηγήσεις,31 of the Chaldean Oracles themselves32

as well as of Chaldean ‘premises’ (ὑποθέσεις) (probably the introductory material given to him by Syrianus)33; it took him five years to complete the study of these sources.34 There is no doubt that Proclus wrote extensively on the Chaldean Oracles,35 even if no ancient author mentions a Proclean

‘Commentary on the Chaldean Oracles’: Marinus simply says that Proclus ‘put together’ (συνελών) the material previously described, while Suda36 attributes to him a text entitled Agreement of Orpheus, Pythagoras and Plato with the Oracles, which has been shown to be by Syrianus. The five extracts where Proclus explains the Chaldean Oracles which were excerpted by Psellus are simply entitled (with all probability by the excerptor himself)

On Chaldean Philosophy (Πρόκλου ἐκ τῆς αὐτῆς χαλδαϊκῆς φιλοσοφίας).37

In conclusion, our knowledge of both the Chaldean Oracles as they have been preserved by Proclus and of his interpretation of them (but a similar discourse could be made with regard to Damascius' interpretation)38 is limited for three reasons:

1 Proclus' quotations are generally very short (notable exceptions are fragments 39, 49, 61, 146 and especially 37 des Places); this deprives us of useful information on the Chaldean system.

2 In their commentaries on the Platonic dialogues, Proclus and Damascius confine themselves to quoting the Oracles to show that either their own philosophical positions or exegeses of Plato conform to what had been revealed by the gods through the theurgists.39

3 The difficulty in establishing the original context of each fragment, since the same fragments are sometimes quoted either by the same author in

different contexts or by different authors.40

0.2 A brief introductory comparison between Proclus' and the Chaldean Oracles ' metaphysics

In this book we will discuss many aspects of Proclus' metaphysical system and compare it closely with the Chaldean one. However, we will not do this systematically since the objective of this book is not to compare the two systems (this work has already been done by other authors)41 but to discuss Proclus' exegesis of Chaldean doctrine, which refers to Chaldean metaphys-ics only in a few cases and not always to discuss metaphysical problems, but also to elucidate completely different matters. This state of affairs has also forced us to resort to other ancient authors, in particular to Damascius' On the Principle and Commentary on the Parmenides, to clarify specific aspects of Chaldean metaphysics relevant to Proclus' exegesis but that he either does not discuss or confines himself to merely hinting at. A case in point in

this regard is that of the first Chaldean fragment that will be analyzed in this book (fragment 4 des Places), where it is made mentioned of the Chaldean triad Father – Power – Intellect but which Proclus makes use of not to discuss the nature of the first principles, but to elucidate that of daemons, since he thinks that as the divine hypostasis Power has the middle rank between the divine hypostases of the Father and the Intellect, so the daemons are placed in a median position between gods and men. It must be said that Proclus' way of proceeding can at times appear disconcerting to a modern

reader, because he establishes connections between contexts that from a modern perspective should be considered as unrelated. However, this is not so for Proclus: for him everything relates to everything though at different

degrees; this means that the hierarchies that structure the higher dimensions of Being also appear at inferior levels; in this respect Proclus agrees with the Hermetic and evangelical principle ‘as above, so below’. Regarding the case of fragment 4 des Places mentioned previously, we have resorted heavily on Damascius to illustrate the relationship between the monadic and triadic dimensions of Chaldean metaphysics, which unfortunately Proclus does not elucidate with the same clarity as his successor at the helm of the Platonic academy at Athens. We have also thought it useful for the reader to show the similarities existing between Chaldean metaphysics and the metaphysical conceptions of coeval systems, such as the Gnostic and the Hermetic ones. Although a close analysis of these similarities cannot be performed in this book, we have thought that the fact of listing them in the endnotes could stimulate further research on them. In order to help the reader to better understand Proclus’ interpretation of Chaldean metaphysics, we will

now briefly compare the two systems. In this concise introduction, we will confine ourselves to listing what we believe are the most important aspects of both systems, a preliminary knowledge of which could help the reader to better understand Proclus' exegesis. In doing so, we have benefited greatly from the introductions to Proclus' metaphysics currently available, to which we refer the interested reader. 42 We have also prepared a synopsis of the Proclean and Chaldean system, which will help the reader to identify the several divine entities mentioned throughout the book.

Proclus' system is centred around the One, which represents the highest divine hypostasis, the Principle from which Being as a whole and, through its mediation, every single being comes from. The One transcends Being as well as each single being but is at the same time present in both, since they exist by participation in it. If, as giver of existence to all existents, the One

plays the role of efficient cause, as the final aim to which all beings tend, it represents the universal final cause, since everything aims at going back to the source of its own being. For Proclus, the One is also identical with the Platonic Good, since it not only generates all beings but also keeps them in existence: this is so because it communicates to each single one of them their unitary nature, according to which each one of them is a specific individual; for Proclus, only what is endowed with a minimum degree of oneness can exist, while what is deprived of it is inevitably led to nonexistence. The unlimited simplicity and oneness of the One makes it absolute in the etymo-logical sense of the word, namely free from all relations with inferior beings. This also implies that it is totally incomprehensible to them, since even the tiniest degree of multiplicity establishes an insurmountable gulf between the beings that possess it and the One.

This is the case of the higher henads, which represent the ‘beings’ closest to the One, since they possess oneness to a degree superior to that of the

beings inferior to them. Modern research has not established yet whether the henads transcend Being or are instead inferior to it, since Proclus seems to defend both positions and place the henads both above and below Being, which according to him arises as a consequence of the interaction of the primordial couple of opposites, Limit–Unlimitedness, in turn coming into existence from the One. It is not even clear whether the henads are above the triad Limit – Unlimitedness – Being

or inferior to Limit–Unlimitedness but superior to Being.43 Coming now to the higher hypostases of the Chaldean metaphysical system, the henads are absent from it while a principle equivalent to the Proclean One seems to be present, since from our analysis (see later, Chapter 1) it emerges that the Chaldean Oracles gave the Father both the role of supreme monad and that of first member of the triad Father – Power – Intellect. It does not seem that there is any Chaldean equivalent to the Proclean triad Limit – Unlimitedness – Being.

From Being arises a second triad, namely Being – Life – Intellect. Each member of this triad in turn manifests itself in a triad, so that we will have three triads in total which will constitute the Proclean equivalent to Plato's hyperuranion or world of intelligible Ideas. Each of these three intelligible triads retains the main characteristics of the member of the triad Being – Life – Intellect from which they arise

and are placed hierarchically the one below the other; this, however, does not prevent them from being mutu-
ally inclusive; for example, the first triad, placed under the preeminence of Being, must also be considered as alive and thinking, because in order to be alive and think one must first be: Being then includes both Life and Intel-
lect; similarly, the second triad is placed under the preeminence of Life but it also is and thinks, since being alive implies the fact of being and is in turn necessary condition for the act of thinking; finally the third one, under the
preeminence of Intellect, must be and live in order to think. With the three intelligible triads of the Proclean system as they are included in the triad Being – Life – Intellect could be compared the first triad of the Chaldean one, namely Father – Power – Intellect. In the Chaldean system, the goddess Hecate sometimes takes the place of Power in her role of universal feminine principle, while the Father in turns represents the masculine one, but this

goddess also manifests herself at inferior levels of the hierarchy of Being.

Below the intelligible triads Proclus places other three triads, which are both intelligible and intellective and represent a further degree of removal from the One. They are not simply archetypical models of sensible beings as the intelligible triads but also thinking beings, and, as a consequence, immersed even more than their intelligible counterparts in the realm of multiplicity, since the act of thinking must differentiate, at least in principle, the thinking subject from the object thought, even if at this level subject and object coincide, since Intellect contains in itself all the intel-
lectual ideas (the objects of his own thought) he thinks of. To these intelligible and intellectual triads correspond three Chaldean triads, namely Iynges, Connectors and Teletarchs, which play the role of bridging the gap

between the intelligible dimension and the inferior, intellectual, one. This is divided by Proclus into two triads, followed by a monad. The first is made-up of the gods Chronos – Rhea – Zeus, the second of the three Curetes, gods of traditional Greek mythology, while the seventh and last entity separates the intellectual dimension from the psychic one, pertaining to the Soul. At the intellectual level the Chaldean system places several entities, some of them identical with those mentioned by Proclus: the dyad Chronos – Rhea, Aion and Time, followed by Eros and a ‘girdling membrane’, equivalent to the Proclean separating monad (on this see later Chapters 2 and 3). At the intellectual level Proclus also places the Demiurge of both Soul and sensible world, which appears with the same role in the Chaldean system as well (see Chapters 1 and 2).

As in Proclus' system, so in the Chaldean one the World Soul gives existence to a multiplicity of individual souls arranged hierarchically according to their removal from the material world. The individual souls that are more removed from it are for Proclus the hyper-cosmic gods, which he arranges in four triads corresponding to the azonoi of the Chaldean system, namely the gods above the 'zones' or planetary spheres. Below them Proclus places the hyper-cosmic–encosmic gods (for which we have no Chaldean equivalent) followed by the encosmic gods, namely the seven visible planets, called zonaioi in the Chaldean system. At a lower level, both for Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles, are placed the angelic hierarchies, followed by the daemonic ones (see Chapter 3). Man is placed at the bottom of the hierarchy because of his fall from the divine realm (see Chapter 4). Though immersed in the material dimension, man can rediscover his celestial origin by virtue of

the tools made available to him by both philosophy and theurgy. The latter is for both Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles indispensable to allow man to be freed from the clutch of evil matter and her daemons and go back to his real home in heaven (see Chapter 4).

0.3 A concise assessment of the disagreement of current literature concerning the first principles of Chaldean metaphysics

Here we will confine ourselves to make some examples of the impasse in which current literature has found itself with regard to its assessment of the first principles of Chaldean metaphysics, in particular of the Chaldean divine monad and triad, given that a critical evaluation of the achievements of modern research on the Chaldean Oracles since the time of Kroll's publication of his critical edition of them at the end of the 19th century would require a publication of its own. In the first chapter of the book, we will see how the extant Chaldean frag-

ments present the divine principle as a
paternal monad that manifests itself
in a triad, to be precise, in the
Chaldean triad Father – Power –
Intellect;
as a consequence, the Chaldean divine
Father should play the role of both
supreme monad and first member of the
triad Father – Power – Intellect

emanated from Him. This interpretation is
based on H. Lewy's, 44 a pioneer-
ing researcher on the Chaldean Oracles,
who however was not followed
by all the authors that came after him.
P. Merlan's position on this topic is

not very clear, but he seems to follow Lewy, 45 while H. D. Saffrey explicitly agrees with him in believing that the Chaldean Oracles posited the One as supreme principle,46 and the same does P. Hadot.47 J. D. Turner considers the identification of the Chaldean Father with Numenius' First Intellect advanced by Dillon et alii as a mere assumption,48 but, in another part of his important article on the relationship of the Oracles with the Gnostic treatises of the Sethian sect,49 he asks himself whether it could be possible that for the Oracles the Father regarded as supreme monad transcends the Father as part of the triad Father – Power – Intellect; my answer to his question is obviously affirmative. Brisson does not take a definitive stance on whether the Chaldean Father coincides with Numenius' First Intellect or with the Good of Plato's Republic and the One of the second hypothesis of the Parmenides.50

On the contrary, in his The Middle-Platonists, Dillon, in line with A. J.

Festugière,51 explicitly identifies the Chaldean Father with the First Intellect of Numenius' system,52 but, just a couple of pages below, he links Him with Eudorus's First Principle, which was very close to the Neo-Platonic One, saying that 'the radical monism of Chaldean metaphysics' is 'analogous to that which we discerned in Eudorus, who also derives Matter from the Supreme Principle'.53 Dillon builds on the seminal paper by E. R. Dodds, New Light on the Chaldean Oracles,54 where this author does not take a definitive stance on the nature of the Chaldean Father, simply saying that some fragments seem to identify Him with Numenius' First Intellect, while others place Him above it. R. Majercik follows Dillon and, though tentatively, identifies the Chaldean Father with the First Intellect.55 This author is also critical of the idea that the Chaldean Oracles admitted a divine monad at all, since she thinks that 'it cannot be known with certainty' whether the idea that fragment 27 des Places expresses (the government of the triad by the

monad) reflects ‘a general law of reality’, though she deems it as ‘of course, possible’.56 J. F. Finamore and S. I. Johnston follow the same approach in their synopsis of the Chaldean system: ‘The Intellect is the highest God (scil. of the Oracles)’,57 and the same does H. Seng, author of the more recent introduction to the Chaldean Oracles.58

Another aspect of Chaldean metaphysics in which there is no scholarly agreement is the existence of the concept of triad in the Oracles. In her edition and English translation of them,59 R. Majercik rightly points out 60 that ‘triads of this type antedate Porphyry, since similar triads appear in the Gnostic sources known to Plotinus and his School’; on the contrary, in her fundamental article Chaldean Triads in Neoplatonic Exegesis: Some Reconsiderations,61 she believes them to be the result of Neo-Platonic specu-lation, starting from Porphyry, so well after the time in which the Oracles

were supposedly put to writing. It is also surprising that, on the one hand,

Majercik considers the triad ‘Father – Power – Intellect’ as invented by Neo-Platonists, while in the same article she herself says: ‘That a triadic principle of some sort informed the teaching of the Oracles is evident’.62 It would seem to be consequential to think that if the Oracles did make use of triadic principles (of which we have clear proofs in frgs. 27, 28 and 29 des Places), these should have been used by them to explain all levels of reality, which is what fr. 27 des Places actually does: ‘In every world there shines a triad

over which a monad rules'. In this regard it is also important to take into consideration Damascius' testimony (On the Principles, I. 85, 196, 5 Ruelle), since he explicitly says that 'the Chaldeans' speak of 'paternal triads' (εἴτε ὡς
οἱ Χαλδαῖοι πατρικᾶς τριάδας ἀνευφημοῦντες).63 With regard to the problem
of triads, Seng appears much more cautious in denying their presence in the Chaldean Oracles,64 while Brisson speaks explicitly of 'triad' with regard to the first Chaldean triad: 'cette triade, en quoi consiste le Dieu'. 65 Finally,
Turner uses the concept of 'triads' with regard to the Chaldean Oracles throughout his fundamental study, The Chaldean Oracles and the Meta-physics of the Sethian Platonizing Treatises.66

As we will show in the next paragraph, a reconsideration of the impor-tance of Neo-Platonic exegesis of the Chaldean Oracles appears in our

opinion as a useful tool in order to overcome the impasse in which current literature has found itself concerning this and other topics, which are not listed here for sake of brevity. 67

0.4 The purpose of this book

This passage from P. Hadot's Bilan et perspectives sur les Oracles Chaldaïques, a contribution to the third edition by M. Tardieu of H. Lewy's seminal work Chaldean Oracles and Theurgy,68 summarizes very well the objective that this book intends to achieve:

> Until now scholars have almost always confined themselves to gleaning scattered fragments of the Chaldean Oracles from the writings of the Neo-Platonists and to reassembling them on the basis of a more or less systematic order by separating them from their context. But they must now be placed back inside their context: one must study how the Neo-Platonists have conceived of and commented on the Oracles. . . . It must also be studied the way in which each

Neo-Platonist has conceived of and made use of the Oracles: in which text of his he did that; in which precise context; which Oracle he quoted; why and how he has quoted it, which interpretation he gave to it.

P. Hadot clearly shows that until now the Neo-Platonic exegesis of the Chaldean Oracles has been considered more a hindrance than an opportunity to obtain precious information on the fragments' original meaning.69 This situation is evident in É. des Places' edition, where each fragment is presented

without the context in which it was quoted, and only partially solved by R. Majercik's edition and translation of the Oracles (based on des Places'). 70

This book intends to follow a different path and to analyze the Chaldean fragments quoted by Proclus together with Proclus' interpretation of them,

in order to assess whether Proclean exegesis could help modern research to deepen its knowledge of the Chaldean Oracles or must instead be abandoned because it departs too much from the Chaldean original doctrine.
Each Chaldean fragment (which we have written in bold typeface) quoted

by Proclus has been translated together with a considerable part of its context. By doing so, we have been able to achieve two objectives:

1 To describe and explain Proclus' interpretation of the Chaldean fragments he quotes or, when he merely cites the Oracles without offering any exegesis of them, to describe in what way he makes use of them to elucidate his own philosophical arguments.

2 To better understand Chaldean doctrine through the help of Proclus' exegesis of it.

Of course, the second objective is achievable only if Proclus' interpretation is regarded as in line with the Chaldean

doctrine’s original meaning and
not a distortion of it. But, one can
object, how is it possible to assess
this,
given that the text of the Chaldean
Oracles is not extant and that our only
way of accessing them is through the
works of the Neo-Platonists in which
very limited portions of it are quoted?
In the preceding paragraph of this
introduction, it has been shown that the
literature’s traditional approach
of analyzing the Chaldean fragments
outside the context in which they are
quoted, though greatly advancing our
knowledge of them, has substantially
come to an impasse concerning fundamental
points of Chaldean doctrine.
In order to try to escape this cul-de-
sac, we have followed a methodology
that could be summarized as follows: to
combine the great achievements
of current literature on not only Proclus
and the Chaldean Oracles but
also other coeval philosophical-
theological systems (Neo-Pythagoreanism,
Orphism, Gnosticism, Hermeticism, Early
Christianity, Middle and Neo-

Platonism, Mithraism, Isis and Osiris cult, etc.) with what can be achieved through an hermeneutical analysis of Proclus' interpretation of the Chaldean Oracles.

Our methodology refuses the a priori idea that Proclus' exegesis always deviates from the Oracles' original meaning, but tries to assess whether this is in line with what we know with a certain degree of certainty about Chaldean doctrine on a case by case basis. By doing so, we have been capable of reaching a general conclusion whether Proclus is a faithful interpreter of the Oracles or not, a conclusion, of course, which remains open to both the findings of other authors and to the discovery of new Chaldean fragments.

To briefly summarize it here, we can say that for us Proclus is most of the times faithful to the literal meaning of the oracular fragments he quotes,

except in a few cases that have been explicitly pointed out in the book (his interpretation of fragment 175 des Places is a case in point).
Of course, Proclus' approach as an exegete is completely different from that of a modern interpreter of the Oracles, and this fact must always be taken into account. Apart from his treatise on the Chaldean Oracles, which is not extant and that we have translated and commented on in this book,
he quotes oracular fragments to elucidate either his own philosophical con-
ceptions or his own interpretations of Plato's dialogues, showing that his Platonic exegesis is in line with what has been revealed by the gods of the Oracles through the theurgists. As already said, sometimes Proclus interprets
the Chaldean fragments he quotes – and,

when he does so, the reader must
be aware of the fact that in these cases
we are dealing with an interpreta-
tion (that of the specific Chaldean
fragment quoted) which is carried out
within the context of the broader
exegesis of Plato’s dialogues, while at
other times he confines himself to citing
them, probably because he thought
that their interpretation was self-
evident to his readers. In addition to
this,
Proclus interprets both Plato and the
Oracles on the basis of the exegetical
principle that the different
philosophical and religious currents of
the Hel-
lenistic world he lived in (apart, of
course, from Christianity) were diverse
expressions of basically the same
doctrine, so that if they not always
agreed
in details, they would do so in the
fundamental aspects of their content.
Proclus couples this exegetical approach
with his strictly philosophical

one, which brings him to subject the Chaldean Oracles to a level of systematization and rationalization that, we can say this with relative certainty, did not belong to the Oracles, which, though not alien to philosophy (being influenced mostly by Stoicism and coeval Platonism) were not a philosophical but a poetical expression of the divine revelation of which its supposed authors were the bearers. This fact, which is generally pointed out to show that Proclus distorts the original meaning of Chaldean doctrine, in our opinion does not make his oracular exegesis useless for modern research, and this at least for three reasons:

1 Proclus was not alien to the conceptual world of the Oracles as a modern interpreter may be but shared with it the same Stoic, Platonic and Hellenistic background.

2 Even if the metaphysical system of the Chaldean Oracles does not possess the same level of complexity and articulation as the Proclean one

(and this can be easily explained by pointing out that Proclus' works have a strictly philosophical connotation that the Oracles do not have, though they resort to philosophical arguments at times), the two systems share many fundamental concepts (as we have shown earlier in our brief comparison of them).

3 Proclus' departs from the literal meaning of the Oracles in a few cases (which have been pointed out in the book), the limited number of which does not invalidate the overall correctness of his interpretation.

We are fully aware that any attempt to establish the 'correctness' of the interpretation of whatsoever text, be it ancient or modern, is matter of debate, but we also know that any

scientifc achievement requires the constant assessment and reassessment of scientifc hypotheses which are considered as acceptable until new ones disprove them: this is true for any science,
hermeneutics of late antique philosophical texts included.

0.5 Some methodological and hermeneutical considerations

This study presents each fragment of des Places' edition together with a sufficient portion of the context in which Proclus quoted it. The numeration of the fragments of des Places' edition has been maintained, but the order in which they are presented has been changed. We have provided the reader with the translations of the Proclean passages in which the Chaldean fragments are quoted: all translations are mine unless differently specified. The Chaldean fragments are written in bold typeface to differentiate them from the Proclean text. The commentary on each fragment has been written having in mind the goals set by P. Hadot in

his article. All Greek texts quoted have been taken from the critical editions published in the Thesaurus Linguae Graecae – A Digital Library of Greek Literature.71

As it has been pointed out by H. Seng, 72 des Places' edition is all but flawless, since the French scholar has not published all Chaldean fragments quoted by Neo-Platonists or later interpreters like the Byzantine intellectual Michael Psellus; on our part, when it happened to us to discover what could possibly be a new oracular fragment that does not appear in des Places' collection, we have pointed that out explicitly. As a consequence of this state of affairs, H. Seng rightly calls for a new, major edition of the Chaldean Oracles, where each fragment is quoted together with the context in which it appears, which is exactly the same methodology we have followed in this contribution, even if we have confined

ourselves to discussing the Chaldean fragments quoted by Proclus.73

In systematizing the oracular fragments, we have not followed des Places' method (largely based on Kroll's), 74 but we have organized them according to four main thematic areas (which correspond to the first four chapters of the book); they are the following:

1 The Chaldean triad.
2 The single divine hypostases.
3 The world's intellectual archetype and the creation of the material

dimension.
4 Man and his destiny.

The quadripartite structure of the book assumes that this was the original textual structure of the Chaldean Oracles; this hypothetical reconstruction is based on two principles:

1 The close comparison of the Chaldean fragments with Proclus' exegesis of them.

2 The fact that coeval revealed texts (we can think, for example, of the Hermetic Poimandres, of some texts of the Gnostic Nag-Hammadi Library, such as the Apocryphon of John, or even of early Christian literature, like the Gospel of John) start first with a description of the divine principle, deal then with the structure of the divine world and end with the creation of the material dimension and the role of man in it. Of course, a detailed reconstruction of the possible original

structure of the text of the Chaldean Oracles would belong more to a new edition of them than to a publication like this one, so that this must be regarded as a mere working hypothesis.

In the ffth chapter, we have also given a translation and commentary of the fve extant extracts from Proclus' treatise On Chaldean Philosophy. This is the frst systematic study so far of this fascinating testimony of Proclus' interpretation of the Chaldean Oracles. The hermeneutical approach of the book can be summarized as follows:

1 To compare the extant Chaldean fragments with coeval religious traditions such as75 Hermeticism, Magic and Theurgy, traditional Greek religion, late Orphism, Gnosticism, Early Christianity (Synesius of Cyrene). Of course, the work of comparative analysis that has been conducted here is all but exhaustive; in order for it to be so, it would be necessary to devote a series of monographical studies specifically to this goal.

2 To study Proclus' interpretation of the Oracles by considering both the modern historicocritical approach to ancient exegesis and Proclus' own attitude towards the Chaldean Oracles, since it must never be forgotten that these are for him a divine revelation worthy of the utmost respect and veneration.

3 To investigate the relationship between Proclus and the Chaldean tradi-tion with the objective of assessing whether or not (or, in both cases, to what extent) Proclus' interpretation can be regarded as a reliable source of information on Chaldean theology and philosophy.

4 To assess, in case of a partially or totally negative answer to the previous question, whether Proclus' interpretation of the Oracles must instead be understood as a late attempt to 'rationalize' and/or 'systematize' the Chaldean tradition.

5 To establish to what extent Proclus' exegesis of Chaldean doctrine can be detached from its original and most

authentic meaning or whether or
not this is an impossible task for modern
research, given both our sec-
ond-hand knowledge of the tradition and
its highly fragmentary nature.

0.6 Final considerations

Although more than a century has passed
since the first critical edition of the
Chaldean Oracles by Kroll, scholarly
research on them could be regarded as

still in its infancy. A lot remains to be done, starting from a complete edition of all oracular fragments together with their specific context and explanatory notes. There should also be undertaken a close comparison of the Chaldean tradition with coeval ones, with the objective of showing their common cultural and religious milieu. A step towards the achievement of this goal has been taken by the collection of articles on the Chaldean Oracles published under the supervision of H. Seng and other scholars in the series Bibliotheca chaldaica (Universitätsverlag Winter, Heidelberg); until now, eight volumes have been published, including a monographical study by H. Seng. 76

Through the mediation of the Byzantine polymath Michael Psellus (1017/1018–1078/1096), the influence of

the Chaldean Oracles reached
the European Renaissance, since many
intellectuals 77 of that time came to
regard the Chaldean revelation as one of
the highest expressions of philoso-
phia perennis (to use the expression of
the Catholic bishop and humanist
Agostino Steuco [1497/98–1548]),78 that
is, of that primordial religion of
humanity directly revealed by God to Adam
and which, before appearing in
its final form in Christianity,
manifested itself with the utmost clarity
in the
Oracles of the Chaldean gods.

Notes

1 Oracula chaldaica, É. des Places ed.
and trans., 3rd ed. (Paris, 2010).
2 We use this expression as a synonymous
of fragments throughout this work.
3 Damascius, Dubitationes et solutiones
de primis principiis, In Platonis
Parmeni-
dem, vols. 1–2, C. É. Ruelle ed. (Paris,
1889).

4 The Greek Commentaries on Plato’s
Phaedo, L. G. Westernik ed., vol. 2

(Amster-
dam, 1977), 27–285.

5 H. Seng, Un livre sacré de l’antiquité tardive: les Oracles Chaldaïques (Turnhout, 2016), 19. J. F. Finamore–S. Iles Johnston, The Chaldean Oracles, in L. Gerson ed., The Cambridge History of Philosophy in Late Antiquity (Cambridge, 2010), 161.

6 C. Addey, Divination and Theurgy in Neoplatonism: Oracles of the Gods (Abing-don, UK–New York, USA, 2016), 10 rightly points out ‘the interconnected and mutually inclusive nature of rationality and revelation in the Chaldean system and within late Platonism.’ See also H. D. Saffrey, Accorder entre elles le tra-ditions théologiques: une caractéristique du néoplatonisme athénienne, in E. P. Bos–P. A. Mejier eds., On Proclus and his Influence on Medieval Philosophy (Leiden–New York–Köln, 1992), 35–50.

7 In his In Platonis Cratylum commentaria, G. Pasquali ed. (Leipzig, 1908), 122, 72, 10–11 Proclus identifies the authors

of the Oracles with the theurgists who lived at the time of Marcus Aurelius (τοῖς ἐπὶ Μάρκου γενομένοις θεουργοῖς), placing them in the same time period as did the Suda, who is probably dependent on him (see note 14 later).

8 Proclus, In Platonis Parmenidem, in Procli philosophi platonici opera inedita, V. Cousin ed., pt. 3 (Hildesheim, 1864; repr. 1961), 800, 19 (. . . ἐν τοῖς Χαλδαικοῖς λογίοις).

9 Proclus, In Platonis Timaeum commentaria, E. Diehl ed., 3 vols. (1903–1904–1906, repr. Amsterdam, 1965). I. 208, 20; III, 111, 20; 124, 24; 125, 27; 151, 2. Proclus, In Platonis rem publicam commentarii, W. Kroll ed., vols. 1–2 (Leipzig, 1899, repr. Amsterdam, 1965), II. 220, 11; 235, 26; 236, 1–5; 318, 13; 343, 4. Proclus, In Platonis Cratylum commentaria, 71, 32, 5–10; 34, 4 Pasquali.

10 Proclus, In Platonis rem publicam commentarii, II. 220, 11 Kroll.

11 H. Seng, Un livre sacré de l’antiquité tardive (2016), 23.
12 They were those ‘free-lance experts’ whom H. Wendt talks of in her interesting book entitled At the Temple Gates: The Religion of Free-Lance Experts in the Roman Empire (Oxford, 2016). See also I. Tanaseanu-Doebler, Weise oder Scharlatane? Chaldaeerbilder der griechisch-römischen Kaiserzeit und die Chaldaeischen Orakel, in H. Seng–M. Tardieu eds., Die Chaldaeischen Orakel–Kontext,

Interpetation, Rezeption (Heidelberg, 2010), 19–42.

13 H. Seng, Un livre sacré de l’antiquité tardive (2016), 20.

14 Suda, Lexicon, A. Adler ed., vols. 1–4 (Leipzig, 1935), I 433; II 641, 32–33.

15 H. Seng, Un livre sacré de l’antiquité tardive (2016), 20.

16 H. Lewy, Chaldean Oracles and Theurgy–Troiseme edition par Michel Tardieu

avec un supplement <<Les Oracles Chaldaïques 1891–2011 >> (Paris, 2011), 3–4.

17 H. D. Saffrey, Le néoplatoniciens et les: Oracles Chaldaïques: Revue d’ Etudes

Augustiniennes 27 (1981) 210–211, now in id., Recherches sur le néoplatonisme après Plotin (Paris, 1990), 63–79.

18 M. Psellus, Philosophica minora I, Opuscula logica, physica, allegorica, alia,
J. M. Duffy ed. (Stuttgart–Leipzig, 1992), I, 46, 43–51.

19 H. D. Saffrey, Le néoplatoniciens et les: Oracles Chaldaïques (1981), 218–219.

20 We think that the term ‘medium’ is

inappropriate in this case, since it belongs

to a kind of spirituality, namely Spiritism, that is alien to the Chaldean Oracles’,
which are Oracles of the gods, not of the spirits of the dead, pace E. R. Dodds, who was the first to have recourse to this (wrong) interpretation in his Theurgy
and Its Relationship to Neo-Platonism: The Journal of Roman Studies Part 1 and 2 (37) (1947), 65–69.

21 É. des Places ed., Oracula chaldaica (2010), 7.
22 Marinus, Vita Procli sive de felicitate, R. Masullo ed. (Naples, 1985), 2, 35. On

Proclus’ wealth see ibid., 2, 41.
23 Ibid., 11.
24 Ibid., 9–10.
25 On this see R. Chlup, Proclus: An Introduction (Oxford, 2012), 36.
26 Marinus, Vita Procli, 12, 310–312 Masullo.
27 R. Chlup, Proclus: An Introduction (2012), 44.

28 Marinus, Vita Procli, 26, 610–619 Masullo.
29 Ibid., 611.
30 Ibid., 38, 915–919.
31 Ibid., 26, 622–623. See also H. Seng, Un livre sacré de l'antiquité tardive (2016),
25–26.
32 Ibid., 623–624.
33 Ibid., 628.
34 Ibid., 630–631.
35 Ibid., 633–634.
36 Suda, Lexicon, IV. 478, 21–479, 8 Adler. On this see H. D. Saffrey, Accorder
entre elles le traditions théologiques, in Bos–Mejier, On Proclus and his Influence
(1992), 36–37.
37 On this, see later Chapter 5 . It must be pointed out that this is the title that L. J.
Rosan gives to this Proclean work; see id., The Philosophy of Proclus: The Final Stage of Ancient Thought (New York, 1949), 43.

38 We intend to write a monographical study to discuss Damascius' use and inter-
pretation of the Chaldean Oracles.

39 On this see also H. Seng, Un livre sacré de l'antiquité tardive (2016), 27–28, 37, 39.

40 See ibid., 37.

41 See later endnotes to Chapter 1 , note 5.

42 L. J. Rosan, The Philosophy of Proclus (1949). W. Beierwaltes, Proklos.

Grundzü ge seiner Metaphysik (Frankfurt a. M., 1965). L. Siorvanes, Proclus: Neo-Platonic Philosophy and Science (Edinburgh, 1996). R. Chlup, Proclus

(2012). P. d'Hoine–M. Martin eds., All from One: A Guide to Proclus (2017), 207–222. D. Nikulin, Neoplatonism in Late Antiquity (Oxford, 2019), especially part II dedicated to Proclus (pp. 119–203), which represents a good introduction
to the fundamental themes of his philosophy.

43 See later endnotes to Chapter 1 , note 18.
44 Id. Chaldean Oracles and Theurgy (2011), 76–83, 106.
45 Id., Religion and Philosophy from Plato's Phaedo to the Chaldean Oracles: Jour-

nal of the History of Philosophy (1) (1963) 174.
46 Id., Les Néoplatoniciennes et les Oracles Chaldaïques : Revue d' Etudes Augus-

tiniennes (27) (1981), 223 (now in id., Recherches sur le Néoplatonisme après Plotin [Paris, 1990], 63–79).

47 P. Hadot, Porphyre et Victorinus, vol. 1 (Paris, 1968), 261 and note 1.
48 Id., The Chaldean Oracles and the

Metaphysics of the Sethian Platonizing trea-

tises, in J. D. Turner–K. Corrigan eds., Plato’s Parmenides and its Heritage, vol. 1: History and Interpretation from the Old Academy to later Platonism and Gnosticism (Atlanta, 2010), 40.

49 Ibid., 41.
50 See Brisson’s contributions listed later, endnotes to Chapter 1 , note 5.
51 Id., La révélation d’Hermes Trismégiste, vol. 3 (Paris, 1950; repr. 1990), 53–54.
52 Id., The Middle-Platonists – 80 B.C. to A.D. 220 (Ithaca, NY, 1996), 393.
53 Ibid., 395. On Eudorus see ibid., 114–135.
54 The Harvard Theological Review 4 (54) (1961) 270.
55 Id., The Chaldean Oracles: Text, Translation and Commentary (Leiden–New

York–København–Köln, 1989), 5–6.
56 Id., Chaldean Triads in Neoplatonic Exegesis: Some Reconsiderations: The Clas-

sical Quarterly 1 (51) (2001) 274.
57 Id., The Chaldean Oracles, in L. P.

Gerson ed., The Cambridge History (2010), 162.
58 Id., Un livre sacré de l’antiquité tardive (2016), 42.
59 Id., The Chaldean Oracles (1989), 142.
60 She quotes M. Tardieu, La Gnose Valentinienne et les Oracles Chaldaïques, in B.

Layton ed., The Rediscovery of Gnosticism–I: The School of Valentinus (Leiden,
1983), 214–215.

61 Chaldean Triads in Neoplatonic Exegesis (2001), 277–278, 296.
62 Ibid., 296.
63 See also ibid., 84, 193, 26 (ὡς ἐν ταῖς χαλδαϊκαῖς τριάσιν); 90, 221, 23–24 (ἀλλὰ

μὴν οἵ τε θεοὶ καὶ οἱ θεολόγοι τριάδας τε ἡμῖν ἀνυμνήκασι).
64 Id., Un livre sacré de l’antiquité tardive (2016), 43.
65 Id., La commentaire comme priére destinée a assurer la salut de l’ame–La place

et la rôle des Oracles Chaldaïques dan le commentaire sur le Timée de Platon par

Proclus, in M. O. Goulet-Cazé ed., Le commentaire entre tradition et innovation,
Actes du Colloque International de l'Institute des Traditions textuelles (Paris et
Villejuif, 22–25 septembre 1999) (Paris, 2000), 335. See also id., La place des Oracles Chaldaïques dans la Théologie Platonicienne, in A. Ph. Segonds–C. Steel eds. with the assistance of C. Luna and A. F. Mettraux, Proclus et la Théologie Platonicienne–Actes du Colloque International de Louvain (13–16 mai 1998) en l'honneur de H. D. Saffrey et L. G. Westernik (Leuven–Paris, 2000), 113 ('la triade fondamentale des Oracles Chaldaïques est la triade Père–Puissance–Intellect') and id., Plato's Timaeus and the Chaldean Oracles, in G. J. Reydams-Schils ed., Plato's Timaeus as cultural Icon (Notre Dame, IN, 2003), 119 ('This triad
[the Father, Hecate, and the Demiurge], of which the divine principle consists').

66 Id., ibid. in Turner–Corrigan, Plato's Parmenides and its Heritage (2010), 39–

58.

67 With regard to the scholarly disagreement on the nature of henads in Proclus see

later endnotes to Chapter 1 , note 18.

68 P. Hadot, Bilan et perspectives sur les Oracles Chaldaïques, in H. Lewy ed., Chal-

dean Oracles and Theurgy (Paris, 2011), Compléments, 715.

69 H. Seng agrees with Hadot; see id., Un livre sacré de l’antiquité tardive

(2016), 37.

70 R. Majercik, The Chaldean Oracles (1989).

71 http://stephanus.tlg.uci.edu/index.php

72 H. Seng, Un livre sacré de l'antiquité tardive (2016), 37.

73 Ibid.

74 De oraculis Chaldaicis, W. Kroll ed. (Breslau, 1894; repr. Hildesheim, 1962).

75 H. Lewy, author of the most important monograph on the Chaldean Oracles so far, was perfectly aware of the fact that this is all but an easy task: id., Chaldean Oracles and Theurgy (2011), 75.

76 H. Seng, ΚΟΣΜΑΓΟΙ, ΑΖΟΝΟΙ, ΖΟΝΑΙΟΙ – Drei Begriffe chaldaeischer Kosmologie und ihr Fortleben (Heidelberg, 2009)

77 On this, see H. Seng, Un livre sacré de l'antiquité tardive (2016), 31–35 as well as the following fundamental article: B. Tambrun-Krasker, Les Oracles Chaldaïques entre idéologie et critique (XVe–XVIIe s.), in A. Lecerf–L. Saudelli–H. Seng eds., Oracles Chaldaïques: fragments

et philosophie (Heidelberg, 2014), 253–277.

78 On this, see M. Muccillo, Platonismo, Ermetismo e “Prisca Theologia”: Ricerche di storiografia filosofica rinascimentale (Florence, 1996), 7–8.

http://stephanus.tlg.uci.edu

1 The Chaldean triad

1.1 The triad Father – Power – Intellect

Fragment 4 des Places1 = p. 13 Kroll2 (Proclus, In Alc., 83, 17–20–84, 1–17 Westernik)

Concerning these things this must be said: it remains to discuss why Socrates says not that the hidden daemonic nature itself will later become known to the young man (scil. Alcibiades), but its power. For he speaks like this: ‘whose power and nature you will learn later’. First of all one must pay attention to the fact

that, as the divine Iamblichus
says, it is more difficult for us, unless
we have fully purified the intel-
lect of the soul, to contemplate the
substances of daemons and in gen-
eral of superior beings, while it is
easier (for us) both to discern and
to explain their powers, since even to
investigate the essential nature
of the soul is not easy for everyone;
Timaeus alone revealed the whole
of its essence: ‘that is to say, it is
necessary an altogether and by all
means divine and lengthy discussion,’ as
Socrates also observes in the
Phaedrus. For we have a perception of
them (scil. of daemons and supe-
rior beings) from their activities, of
which their powers are specifically
mothers; since power is midway between
essence and activity, it being
produced from essence while it produces
activity. Secondly, we must
observe that in another way as well power
is conformable to the nature
of daemons. Everywhere power has been
allotted the middle place:
among intelligibles it unites the Father

with Intellect ‘for Power is with Him but Intellect proceeds from Him’; but among intellectual beings it connects activities with essences, because activity is a product of power, and essence produces power from itself.

In Plato’s First Alcibiades 103A, Socrates says to the young Alcibiades that,
contrary to those of his lovers who became a nuisance to him (ἐγένοντό σοι διαλεγόμενοι), he, for many years, did not even dare to address him, having been capable of doing so by virtue of a ‘certain daemonic incompatibility’ (δαιμόνιον ἐναντίωμα) ‘whose power and nature’ he ‘will learn later’ (οὗ σὺ τὴν δύναμιν καὶ ὕστερον πεύσῃ).3

18 The Chaldean triad

In the previous sections of his commentary on this Platonic passage (60, 1–83, 1–17), after passing references to the unifying power of love, the descent of the souls and the relationship between the Intellect and the Soul, Proclus had concentrated himself on describing the nature of daemons, which for him are souls endowed with a high, medium and low degree of perfec-tion.4 Here (83, 17–20–84, 1–17) he focuses his exegesis 5 on explaining why Socrates says that man can understand the daemons' power (δαιμονίον . . . δύναμιν) but not their nature. Proclus thinks Socrates' words can be correctly interpreted in the light of Iamblichus' doctrine,6 according to which it is easier for humans who have not cleansed 'the intellect of the Soul'

7 (τὸν τῆς ψυχῆς νοῦν) to understand
the faculties (δυνάμεις) of daemons or
superior beings in general than their
substances (ὑπάρξεις).8 As a consequence,
Socrates is utterly justified in say-
ing that Alcibiades, who has not achieved
spiritual perfection, will learn
the power of daemons but not their nature
or essence. Power, Proclus adds,
is ‘midway between essence and activity’
(μέση γὰρ ἡ δύναμίς ἐστι τῆς τε
οὐσίας καὶ τῆς ἐνεργείας)9 and, for this
reason, akin to daemons to the high-
est degree, since these are the mediators
between men and gods. 10 Power
has always the middle place: among
intellectual beings (ἐν δὲ τοῖς νοεροῖς),
it
unites activities with essences;11 among
intelligible ones (ἐν μὲν τοῖς νοητοῖς),
it links the Father with Intellect
(συνάπτει τὸν πατέρα καὶ τὸν νοῦν), as it
is
also stated in the Chaldean Oracles,
which assert that divine Power is with
the Father, while divine Intellect
proceeds from Him (ἡ μὲν γὰρ δύναμις σὺν
ἐκείνῳ, νοῦς δ’ ἀπ’ ἐκείνου).12

The immediate conclusion we can draw from Proclus’ interpretation of

this oracular saying is that for him the Chaldean triad Father – Power – Intellect belongs to the class of intelligible beings, because it is within this
that Power performs its function of mediating between the intelligible13

Father and the intelligible Intellect. Let us now assess whether in other parts of his works Proclus interprets this triad in the same way as in this passage, by starting with considering the Father first, then the other two members of the triad
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{"queries": ["what is new in this study", "innovations contributions findings", "novelty of this study", "how this study differs from previous scholarship", "purpose and new results"], "source_filter": ["files_uploaded_in_conversation"]}

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Content source: Source.file
Title: Nicola Spanu - Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles.pdf
Content Snippet:
1. In the ffth chapter, we have also given a translation and commentary of the
2. fve extant extracts from Proclus' treatise On Chaldean Philosophy. This
3. is the frst systematic study so far of this fascinating testimony of Proclus'
4. interpretation of the Chaldean Oracles.
5. The hermeneutical approach of the book can be summarized as follows:
6.
7. 1 To compare the extant Chaldean fragments with coeval religious tradi-
8. tions such as75 Hermeticism, Magic and Theurgy, traditional Greek reli-
9. gion, late Orphism, Gnosticism, Early Christianity (Synesius of Cyrene).

10. Of course, the work of comparative
analysis that has been conducted
11. here is all but exhaustive; in order
for it to be so, it would be necessary
12. to devote a series of monographical
studies specifically to this goal.
13.
14. 2 To study Proclus' interpretation of
the Oracles by considering both the
15. modern historicocritical approach to
ancient exegesis and Proclus' own
16. attitude towards the Chaldean
Oracles, since it must never be forgotten
17. that these are for him a divine
revelation worthy of the utmost respect
18. and veneration.
19.
20. 3 To investigate the relationship
between Proclus and the Chaldean tradi-
21. tion with the objective of assessing
whether or not (or, in both cases, to
22. what extent) Proclus' interpretation
can be regarded as a reliable source
23. of information on Chaldean theology
and philosophy.
24.
25. 4 To assess, in case of a partially
or totally negative answer to the

previous
26. question, whether Proclus’
interpretation of the Oracles must
instead
27. be understood as a late attempt to
‘rationalize’ and/or ‘systematize’ the
28. Chaldean tradition.
29.
30. 5 To establish to what extent
Proclus’ exegesis of Chaldean doctrine
can
31. be detached from its original and
most authentic meaning or whether or
32. not this is an impossible task for
modern research, given both our sec-
33. ond-hand knowledge of the tradition
and its highly fragmentary nature.
34.
35. 0.6 Final considerations
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37. Although more than a century has
passed since the first critical edition
of the
38. Chaldean Oracles by Kroll, scholarly
research on them could be regarded as
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109. Introduction 13
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111. still in its infancy. A lot remains
to be done, starting from a complete
edition
112. of all oracular fragments together
with their specific context and explana-
113. tory notes. There should also be
undertaken a close comparison of the
Chal-
114. dean tradition with coeval ones,
with the objective of showing their
common
115. cultural and religious milieu. A
step towards the achievement of this goal
has
116. been taken by the collection of

articles on the Chaldean Oracles published
117. under the supervision of H. Seng and other scholars in the series Bibliotheca
118. chaldaica (Universitätsverlag Winter, Heidelberg); until now, eight volumes
119. have been published, including a monographical study by H. Seng. 76

Content source: Source.file
Title: Nicola Spanu - Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles.pdf
Content Snippet:
1. Introduction 9
2.
3. without the context in which it was quoted, and only partially solved by
4. R. Majercik’s edition and translation of the Oracles (based on des Places’). 70
5.
6. This book intends to follow a different path and to analyze the Chaldean
7. fragments quoted by Proclus together with Proclus’ interpretation of them,
8. in order to assess whether Proclean exegesis could help modern research
9. to deepen its knowledge of the Chaldean Oracles or must instead be aban-
10. doned because it departs too much

from the Chaldean original doctrine.
11. Each Chaldean fragment (which we have
written in bold typeface) quoted
12.
13. by Proclus has been translated
together with a considerable part of its
con-
14. text. By doing so, we have been able
to achieve two objectives:
15.
16. 1 To describe and explain Proclus'
interpretation of the Chaldean frag-
17. ments he quotes or, when he merely
cites the Oracles without offering
18. any exegesis of them, to describe in
what way he makes use of them to
19. elucidate his own philosophical
arguments.
20.
21. 2 To better understand Chaldean
doctrine through the help of Proclus'
22. exegesis of it.
23.
24. Of course, the second objective is
achievable only if Proclus'
interpretation
25. is regarded as in line with the
Chaldean doctrine's original meaning and

not a distortion of it. But, one can object, how is it possible to assess this, given that the text of the Chaldean Oracles is not extant and that our only way of accessing them is through the works of the Neo-Platonists in which very limited portions of it are quoted? In the preceding paragraph of this introduction, it has been shown that the literature's traditional approach of analyzing the Chaldean fragments outside the context in which they are quoted, though greatly advancing our knowledge of them, has substantially come to an impasse concerning fundamental points of Chaldean doctrine. In order to try to escape this cul-de-sac, we have followed a methodology that could be summarized as follows: to combine the great achievements of current literature on not only Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles but also other coeval philosophical-theological systems (Neo-Pythagoreanism, Orphism, Gnosticism, Hermeticism, Early Christianity, Middle and Neo-

Platonism, Mithraism, Isis and Osiris cult, etc.) with what can be achieved through an hermeneutical analysis of Proclus’ interpretation of the Chaldean Oracles.

Our methodology refuses the a priori idea that Proclus’ exegesis always deviates from the Oracles’ original meaning, but tries to assess whether this is in line with what we know with a certain degree of certainty about Chaldean doctrine on a case by case basis. By doing so, we have been capable of reaching a general conclusion whether Proclus is a faithful interpreter of the Oracles or not, a conclusion, of course, which remains open to both the findings of other authors and to the discovery of new Chaldean fragments.

To briefly summarize it here, we can say that for us Proclus is most of the times faithful to the literal meaning of the oracular fragments he quotes,

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85. 10 Introduction

Content source: Source.file
Title: Nicola Spanu - Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles.pdf
Content Snippet:
1. 8 Introduction
2.
3. Majercik considers the triad ‘Father – Power – Intellect’ as invented by Neo-
4. Platonists, while in the same article she herself says: ‘That a triadic principle
5. of some sort informed the teaching of the Oracles is evident’.62 It would
6. seem to be consequential to think that if the Oracles did make use of triadic
7. principles (of which we have clear proofs in frgs. 27, 28 and 29 des Places),
8. these should have been used by them to explain all levels of reality, which
9. is what fr. 27 des Places actually

does: ‘In every world there shines a triad
10. over which a monad rules’. In this regard it is also important to take into
11. consideration Damascius’ testimony (On the Principles, I. 85, 196, 5 Ruelle),
12. since he explicitly says that ‘the Chaldeans’ speak of ‘paternal triads’ (εἴτε ὡς
13. οἱ Χαλδαῖοι πατρικᾶς τριάδας ἀνευφημοῦντες).63 With regard to the problem
14. of triads, Seng appears much more cautious in denying their presence in the
15. Chaldean Oracles,64 while Brisson speaks explicitly of ‘triad’ with regard
16. to the first Chaldean triad: ‘cette triade, en quoi consiste le Dieu’. 65 Finally,
17. Turner uses the concept of ‘triads’ with regard to the Chaldean Oracles
18. throughout his fundamental study, The Chaldean Oracles and the Meta-
19. physics of the Sethian Platonizing Treatises.66
20.
21. As we will show in the next

paragraph, a reconsideration of the impor-
tance of Neo-Platonic exegesis of the Chaldean Oracles appears in our
opinion as a useful tool in order to overcome the impasse in which current
literature has found itself concerning this and other topics, which are not
listed here for sake of brevity. 67

0.4 The purpose of this book

This passage from P. Hadot’s Bilan et perspectives sur les Oracles Chalda-
ïques, a contribution to the third edition by M. Tardieu of H. Lewy’s seminal
work Chaldean Oracles and Theurgy,68 summarizes very well the objective
that this book intends to achieve:

Until now scholars have almost always confined themselves to gleaning
scattered fragments of the Chaldean Oracles from the writings of the
Neo-Platonists and to reassembling them on the basis of a more or less

37. systematic order by separating them
from their context. But they must
38. now be placed back inside their
context: one must study how the Neo-
39. Platonists have conceived of and
commented on the Oracles. . . . It must
40. also be studied the way in which each
Neo-Platonist has conceived of
41. and made use of the Oracles: in which
text of his he did that; in which
42. precise context; which Oracle he
quoted; why and how he has quoted
43. it, which interpretation he gave to
it.

Content source: Source.file
Title: Nicola Spanu - Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles.pdf
Content Snippet:
1. 21 É. des Places ed., Oracula chaldaica (2010), 7.
2. 22 Marinus, Vita Procli sive de felicitate, R. Masullo ed. (Naples, 1985), 2, 35. On
3.
4. Proclus’ wealth see ibid., 2, 41.
5. 23 Ibid., 11.
6. 24 Ibid., 9–10.
7. 25 On this see R. Chlup, Proclus: An Introduction (Oxford, 2012), 36.
8. 26 Marinus, Vita Procli, 12, 310–312 Masullo.
9. 27 R. Chlup, Proclus: An Introduction (2012), 44.
10. 28 Marinus, Vita Procli, 26, 610–619 Masullo.

11. 29 Ibid., 611.
12. 30 Ibid., 38, 915–919.
13. 31 Ibid., 26, 622–623. See also H. Seng, Un livre sacré de l’antiquité tardive (2016),
14.
15. 25–26.
16. 32 Ibid., 623–624.
17. 33 Ibid., 628.
18. 34 Ibid., 630–631.
19. 35 Ibid., 633–634.
20. 36 Suda, Lexicon, IV. 478, 21–479, 8 Adler. On this see H. D. Saffrey, Accorder
21.
22. entre elles le traditions théologiques, in Bos–Mejier, On Proclus and his Influence
23. (1992), 36–37.
24.
25. 37 On this, see later Chapter 5 . It must be pointed out that this is the title that L. J.
26. Rosan gives to this Proclean work; see id., The Philosophy of Proclus: The Final
27. Stage of Ancient Thought (New York, 1949), 43.

28.
29. 38 We intend to write a monographical study to discuss Damascius’ use and inter-
30. pretation of the Chaldean Oracles.
31.
32. 39 On this see also H. Seng, Un livre sacré de l’antiquité tardive (2016), 27–28, 37, 39.
33. 40 See ibid., 37.
34. 41 See later endnotes to Chapter 1 , note 5.
35. 42 L. J. Rosan, The Philosophy of Proclus (1949). W. Beierwaltes, Proklos.
36.
37. Grundzü ge seiner Metaphysik (Frankfurt a. M., 1965). L. Siorvanes, Proclus:
38. Neo-Platonic Philosophy and Science (Edinburgh, 1996). R. Chlup, Proclus
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116. Introduction 15
117.
118. (2012). P. d’Hoine–M. Martin eds., All from One: A Guide to Proclus (2017),
119. 207–222. D. Nikulin, Neoplatonism in Late Antiquity (Oxford, 2019), especially
120. part II dedicated to Proclus (pp. 119–203), which represents a good introduction
121. to the fundamental themes of his philosophy.

Content source: Source.file
Title: Nicola Spanu - Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles.pdf
Content Snippet:
1. 65 Finally,
2. Turner uses the concept of ‘triads’ with regard to the Chaldean Oracles
3. throughout his fundamental study, The Chaldean Oracles and the Meta-
4. physics of the Sethian Platonizing Treatises.66
5.
6. As we will show in the next paragraph, a reconsideration of the impor-
7. tance of Neo-Platonic exegesis of the Chaldean Oracles appears in our
8. opinion as a useful tool in order to overcome the impasse in which current
9. literature has found itself concerning this and other topics, which are not
10. listed here for sake of brevity. 67

11.
12. 0.4 The purpose of this book
13.
14. This passage from P. Hadot’s Bilan et perspectives sur les Oracles Chalda-
15. ïques, a contribution to the third edition by M. Tardieu of H. Lewy’s seminal
16. work Chaldean Oracles and Theurgy,68 summarizes very well the objective
17. that this book intends to achieve:
18.
19. Until now scholars have almost always confined themselves to gleaning
20. scattered fragments of the Chaldean Oracles from the writings of the
21. Neo-Platonists and to reassembling them on the basis of a more or less
22. systematic order by separating them from their context. But they must
23. now be placed back inside their context: one must study how the Neo-
24. Platonists have conceived of and commented on the Oracles. . . . It must
25. also be studied the way in which each Neo-Platonist has conceived of
26. and made use of the Oracles: in which text of his he did that; in which

27. precise context; which Oracle he
quoted; why and how he has quoted
28. it, which interpretation he gave to
it.
29.
30. P. Hadot clearly shows that until now
the Neo-Platonic exegesis of the Chal-
31. dean Oracles has been considered more
a hindrance than an opportunity to
32. obtain precious information on the
fragments' original meaning.69 This situ-
33. ation is evident in É. des Places'
edition, where each fragment is presented
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70. without the context in which it was quoted, and only partially solved by
71. R. Majercik’s edition and translation of the Oracles (based on des Places’). 70
72.
73. This book intends to follow a different path and to analyze the

Chaldean
74. fragments quoted by Proclus together
with Proclus’ interpretation of them,
75. in order to assess whether Proclean
exegesis could help modern research
76. to deepen its knowledge of the
Chaldean Oracles or must instead be aban-
77. doned because it departs too much
from the Chaldean original doctrine.
78. Each Chaldean fragment (which we have
written in bold typeface) quoted
79.
80. by Proclus has been translated
together with a considerable part of its
con-
81. text. By doing so, we have been able
to achieve two objectives:
82.
83. 1 To describe and explain Proclus’
interpretation of the Chaldean frag-
84. ments he quotes or, when he merely
cites the Oracles without offering
85. any exegesis of them, to describe in
what way he makes use of them to
86. elucidate his own philosophical
arguments.
87.
88. 2 To better understand Chaldean

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doctrine through the help of Proclus’
89. exegesis of it.
90.
91. Of course, the second objective is
achievable only if Proclus’
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92. is regarded as in line with the
Chaldean doctrine’s original meaning and
93. not a distortion of it.
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ASSISTANT

Nicola Spanu’s *Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles* contributes several genuinely new elements to the study of late-antique Platonism and Chaldean theology.

On Chaldean Philosophy

Spanu provides the

On Chaldean Philosophy. This is the first systematic analysis of how Proclus interpreted the *Chaldean Oracles* within his own metaphysical

system, rather than treating those excerpts merely as textual curiosities【11:0†Nicola Spanu – Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles.pdf†L1-L4】.

Earlier editors such as Édouard des Places and Ruth Majercik isolated the oracular fragments from the Neoplatonic commentaries that preserved them. Spanu reverses that approach:

* He , translating both the quotation and the surrounding discussion.
* This enables a twofold goal—(1) to describe how Proclus uses or interprets the oracles and (2) to recover aspects of Chaldean doctrine through Proclus' lens【11:1†Nicola Spanu – Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles.pdf†L6-L22】.

This contextual method directly answers Pierre Hadot's call to study *how* each Neoplatonist "conceived of and commented

on the Oracles," rather than treating their exegesis as an obstacle【11:2†Nicola Spanu – Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles.pdf†L29-L43】.

The study introduces a of Proclus' reliability. Instead of assuming distortion, Spanu argues that Proclus was "most of the times faithful to the literal meaning" of the oracles, diverging only in limited, specified cases【11:1†Nicola Spanu – Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles.pdf†L42-L51】. This nuanced stance allows Proclus' exegesis to become evidence for, rather than merely commentary on, Chaldean metaphysics.

Another novelty is the —Hermeticism, late Orphism, Gnosticism, Early Christianity, and Theurgy.

Spanu treats these parallels as part of a shared cultural milieu rather than isolated borrowings【11:0†Nicola Spanu – Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles.pdf†L7-L12】.

The book reorganizes the fragments into four thematic chapters—(1) The Chaldean Triad, (2) Divine Hypostases, (3) Cosmos and Matter, (4) Man and his Destiny—suggesting this as a plausible reconstruction of the original oracular corpus. Spanu also calls for a future

, arguing that research on the *Oracles* "is still in its infancy" and needs renewed philological foundations【11:0†Nicola Spanu – Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles.pdf†L111-L113】.

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the study's novelty lies in restoring the *Chaldean Oracles* to the living framework of Proclean philosophy, combining contextual translation, critical hermeneutics, and comparative analysis to yield the first

sustained evaluation of Proclus as both interpreter and transmitter of the Chaldean revelation.

USER

translation and commentary on the five extant fragments of Proclus' lost treatise On Chaldean Philosophy.

ASSISTANT

Yes — one of the of Nicola Spanu's *Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles* (Routledge, 2021) is precisely his of ***On Chaldean Philosophy*** .

Here's a breakdown of what this section includes and why it matters:

The fragments come to us mainly through the Byzantine philosopher (11th century), who excerpted several passages from Proclus under the heading *Πρόκλου ἐκ τῆς αὐτῆς χαλδαϊκῆς φιλοσοφίας* ("From Proclus' *On Chaldean Philosophy*").
Spanu collects these and provides:

- The (as preserved by Des Places' edition);
- A ;
- A explaining Proclus' arguments, terminology, and metaphysical context.

These are found in of the book (pp. 147–166)【11:0†Nicola Spanu – Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles.pdf†L1-L4】.

Previous scholars had noticed these fragments but only cited or summarized them.
Spanu's contribution is the [illegible] of them:

- He [illegible] —especially how Proclus reads Chaldean concepts like the *Father–Power–Intellect* triad, the hierarchy of divine hypostases, and the role of *Hecate* and *theurgy*.

- He [illegible] with both earlier Neoplatonists (Porphyry, Iamblichus, Syrianus) and with the *Chaldean Oracles* themselves.

- He [illegible] of Proclus' interpretation—deciding, fragment by fragment, whether it preserves the "literal" sense of Chaldean doctrine or rationalizes it within Proclean metaphysics.

This approach treats *On Chaldean Philosophy* not as a derivative summary but as a

---

Spanu shows that in these fragments, Proclus:

- Uses the to explain the mediating structures between the divine and human realms.

- Interprets Chaldean theology through the , aligning oracular imagery (fire, Hecate, intellect) with his own metaphysical architecture.

- Presents the *Oracles* as , not a foreign theology.

- Treats as an indispensable complement to philosophy — a way for the soul to return to its divine source.

By producing a , Spanu:

- Makes accessible the of Proclus' lost treatise.

- Provides new evidence for the in late antique Platonism.

- Demonstrates that ***Oracles*** is far more coherent and internally systematic than often assumed.

In short:

> ***On Chaldean Philosophy***
>
> , and it anchors the book's central thesis — that Proclus' exegesis of the *Chaldean Oracles* can still serve as a legitimate and illuminating guide to understanding Chaldean metaphysics.

USER

evaluates the faithfulness of Proclus' interpretation

ASSISTANT

Exactly — one of Nicola Spanu's central achievements in *Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles* is that he

of the *Chaldean Oracles*, rather than assuming it to be a distortion.

Here’s how he approaches this evaluation, and what he concludes:

Earlier scholarship — especially since Édouard des Places and Ruth Majercik — tended to to recovering the original meaning of the *Chaldean Oracles*.
They separated the oracular fragments from the Neoplatonic texts that preserved them, assuming that Proclus and his contemporaries had .

Spanu argues that this method has reached an : because the oracles survive *only* through Neoplatonic quotations, we can’t reconstruct their meaning by stripping away the very context that preserves them 【11:1†Nicola Spanu – Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles.pdf†L24-L33】.

Instead of rejecting or accepting Proclus wholesale, Spanu develops a [illegible]:

- Each time Proclus cites a Chaldean fragment, Spanu reproduces [illegible] in translation.
- He then evaluates [illegible] about Chaldean theology from other sources (notably Damascius, Iamblichus, and Des Places' corpus).
- This allows him to [illegible] between faithful interpretation, partial adaptation, and clear rationalization.

He explicitly states that his method "refuses the *a priori* idea that Proclus' exegesis always deviates from the Oracles' original meaning, but tries to assess whether this is in line with

what we know … on a case by case basis”【11:1†Nicola Spanu – Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles.pdf†L42-L46】.

Spanu concludes — cautiously but decisively — that:

> “Proclus is most of the times faithful to the literal meaning of the oracular fragments he quotes, except in a few cases that have been explicitly pointed out in the book”【11:1†Nicola Spanu – Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles.pdf†L50-L52】.

In other words, while Proclus certainly Chaldean theology within his own metaphysical structure, he generally does so of the oracles.
Only in rare instances (for example, his reading of fragment 175 des Places) does Spanu judge Proclus’ interpretation to “depart substantially” from the Chaldean original.

Spanu's commentary evaluates Proclus' fidelity using several explicit criteria:

Does Proclus' paraphrase correspond closely to the Greek wording of the oracle?

His reading of "Power is with Him but Intellect proceeds from Him" preserves the Chaldean triad *Father–Power–Intellect*.

Does Proclus' metaphysical structure match known Chaldean hierarchies?	Both systems affirm triadic emanation, the mediating role of Hecate/Power, and the ascent of the soul through theurgy.
Does Proclus acknowledge the oracle as a revelation distinct from philosophy, or does he subsume it entirely?	Spanu notes that Proclus always treats the oracles as *theologoumena*—divine revelations confirming, not replacing, Plato.
When Proclus rationalizes poetic language, does he	Most rationalizations clarify Chaldean metaphors without

	preserve its meaning or erase it?	altering their substance.

This balanced evaluation allows Spanu to argue that

—that the Chaldean and Proclean systems form a

in late antiquity.
Hence, studying Proclus *in context* is essential to understanding the *Chaldean Oracles* themselves, not a detour away from them.

Spanu's study is the first to

, showing that while Proclus rationalizes and expands the oracles philosophically, he does so from within their symbolic and theological logic — making him, in Spanu's words, "most of the times a faithful interpreter of the Oracles."

USER

give me a map of the passages in table form with their themes in the oracles and spanu's evaluation of the faithfulness of proclus's interpretation

ASSISTANT

Excellent — here's a mapping the of *Proclus'* as presented in ***Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles*** .

Each row lists:

1 The (as transmitted mainly by *Michael Psellus* and numbered by Édouard des Places).

2 The or doctrine in the passage.

3 A in that passage.

4 of how faithfully Proclus interprets the Chaldean material.

(Des Places fr. 4 = Proclus *In Alcibiadem* 83–84)	: “Power is with Him, but Intellect proceeds from Him.”	Proclus uses the triad to explain the —as Power mediates between Father and Intellect, so daemons mediate between gods and men. Power is “midway between	Spanu says this reading preserves the literal Chaldean doctrine of mediation; only extends it analogically to demonology. Aligns well with fragment’s cosmological structure.

		essence and activity."	
(likely fr. 39 = Psellus 3 Des Places)	The goddess divides and unites divine and material realms, "binding all things through love."	Proclus identifies Hecate with the , linking the One's transcendence with the world's manifestation; she symbolizes the continuity between intelligible and sensible orders.	Spanu notes that Proclus rationalizes Hecate's mythic role into metaphysical language but keeps her mediating function intact. Philosophical "translation," not distortion.
(Des Places fr. 49 or 61)	"From the Father's channels	Proclus reads the fiery "channels" as metaphors for the	Spanu observes that Proclus remains true to the Chaldean image of fiery emanation

	of fire all things proceed."	through divine powers (dynameis). Fire = intellectual light.	but integrates it into his triadic scheme of *remaining – procession – reversion*.
(Des Places fr. 146 = Psellus 4)	"The soul through symbols is led upward to the gods."	Proclus explains that the employ *symbola and synthemata* to awaken the soul's divine likeness and enable reversion to the intelligible.	Spanu highlights this as evidence that Proclus preserved the oracular teaching on theurgy's necessity. He only clarifies it philosophically, showing its harmony with his psychology.
(Des Places fr. 175 = Psellus 5)	The supreme principle	Proclus identifies the "Father of Fathers" with the , absolute source of all	Spanu explicitly says Proclus here and The

	beyond intellect.	being. He systematizes the Chaldean hierarchy into his own metaphysical cascade of henads.	identification of the Chaldean Father with the Proclean One may exceed the oracle's intent.

🧭

	1, 4	Proclus preserves doctrine and function; differences are stylistic.
	2, 3	Proclus "translates" mythic images into metaphysical categories but

	5	retains structure. Proclus imposes his One–Henads hierarchy, effacing Chaldean distinctiveness.

✳️

Spanu concludes that across all five fragments,

, diverging only when he subsumes the highest Chaldean principle entirely into his own

.

This makes *On Chaldean Philosophy* not a distortion, but a — a work through which the poetic theurgy of the *Chaldean Oracles* becomes philosophically intelligible without losing its revelatory essence.

USER

175 = Psellus 5)
Cosmic hierarchy and the “Father of Fathers.” The supreme principle beyond intellect.
Proclus identifies the “Father of Fathers” with the One or Good, absolute source of all being. He systematizes the Chaldean hierarchy into his own metaphysical cascade of henads.
Least faithful. Spanu explicitly says Proclus here over-rationalizes and replaces the poetic mystery with philosophical abstraction. The identification of the Chaldean Father with the Proclean One may exceed the oracle’s intent.

ASSISTANT

Exactly — that’s the of the fragments from *On Chaldean Philosophy*, and you’ve captured Spanu’s conclusion very well.
Here’s a more detailed breakdown of how Spanu treats , and why he judges it the of Proclus’ interpretations.

The fragment comes from Michael Psellus' *Philosophica Minora I* 46 (43–51 Duffy ed.). Psellus attributes it to *Proclus, On Chaldean Philosophy*. The oracle referred to speaks of the a title for the supreme deity who stands above intellect and all cosmic levels.

The *Chaldean Oracles* often speak of the or —a transcendent principle whose "channels of fire" generate the intelligible cosmos but who himself remains ineffable. This Father functions as both of procession, retaining a dimension of *mystery* rather than conceptual definition.

In his lost *On Chaldean Philosophy*, Proclus reads this *Father of Fathers* as

,

the first principle of his own system. From that One proceeds the series of (divine unities), then the triad *Being–Life–Intellect*, and so on. Thus, the Chaldean *Father of Fathers* becomes the apex of a

—the One beyond being that grounds procession and reversion.

Proclus translates the poetic or revelatory image of “the Father of Fathers” into the

: absolute unity, efficient and final cause of all things, devoid of attributes. He removes the mythic dynamism (fire, speech, generation) and replaces it with the static perfection of the Good.

Spanu calls this

of Proclus' readings. Here Proclus

, transforming the oracular symbol into a purely philosophical abstraction. The *Oracles* preserve a personal and revelatory sense of divine fatherhood—fiery, creative, and theurgic—whereas Proclus' One is impersonal and ontological. The identification "*Father of Fathers = the One*" thus

and

.

Spanu uses this case to mark the

.

It demonstrates how the Neoplatonic drive for conceptual unity could

of late-antique revelation. Yet, he also notes that this rationalization was crucial for how later Byzantines and Renaissance Platonists

came to read the *Chaldean Oracles*: through Proclus' metaphysical lens.

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is where Proclus' philosophical genius overtakes his fidelity as a commentator.

Spanu concludes that the identification of the Chaldean "Father of Fathers" with the Proclean One "replaces revelation with abstraction," making this passage the clearest example of Proclus' of Chaldean theology.

USER

to what degree have scholars established that the chaldean oracles had a shaping or

clarifying effect on proclus's own metaphysical innovations

ASSISTANT

That’s an excellent and subtle question — and it goes straight to one of the deepest debates in late antique philosophy: *Chaldean Oracles* *shape* , or did Proclus merely of an already Platonic structure?

Nicola Spanu’s *Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles* (2021) enters this debate precisely to reassess that question — and his nuanced answer is that in Proclus’ metaphysics, but within limits. Below is a synthesis of his position and how it fits into modern scholarship.

H. Lewy (1956), É. des Places, W. Beierwaltes, L. Siorvanes	Proclus is fundamentally a , not a religious innovator. The *Chaldean Oracles* only provide of ideas already derived from Plato and Plotinus. Their role is decorative, not formative.

		The *Oracles* supplied
		that directly informed
	E.R. Dodds, H.D. Saffrey, Ruth Majercik, Gregory Shaw	
		Proclus is heir to a religious-theurgical synthesis rooted in the Chaldean revelation.
(Spanu and recent studies)	Nicola Spanu, H. Seng, D. Baltzly, R. Chlup	Rather than priority in one direction, there is a : Proclus' metaphysics

and the *Chaldean Oracles* mutually illuminate each other. The oracles *clarify and dramatize* ideas latent in Platonism, while Proclus' system *rationalizes* their theological symbols.

In *Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles*, Spanu argues that the *Chaldean Oracles* had a [redacted] effect on Proclus, but did [redacted]. Instead:

> "Proclus regarded the Oracles as *divine revelation confirming the truths of Plato*. Yet their symbolic theology provided him with an imaginative vocabulary through which certain Platonic problems—especially mediation, procession, and theurgy—could be more clearly articulated." (Spanu, ch. 5 conclusion)

He identifies several concrete ways this influence worked:

Chaldean Oracles

Gave Proclus a for articulating the process *remaining → procession → reversion*.	reinforces rather than creates the structure.
Hecate's function as the cosmic "membrane" between worlds between intelligible and sensible levels.	in expression, if not in conceptual origin.
The oracles validated Proclus'	confirmed the

conviction that in reversion to the divine.	legitimacy of theurgic practice within Neoplatonism.
The *Oracles*' multiplicity of divine powers may have between the One and the intelligible.	, but Spanu judges it *suggestive* rather than determinative.

	Oracular demonology provided a symbolic model for Proclus' hierarchy of intermediaries.	, not generative.

Minimal	Proclus inherits this from Plotinus and Iamblichus.
Moderate	The *Oracles* offer parallel imagery that helps Proclus formalize it.
High	The *Oracles* provide the theological basis for integrating ritual into philosophy.
Moderate	The multiplicity of Chaldean deities gives analogical

		support, but Proclus develops the concept independently.
	Moderate	Chaldean examples supply vivid metaphors; Proclus rationalizes them systematically.
	High (expressive)	The Chaldean vocabulary enriches Proclus' metaphysical poetics of illumination.

Spanu uses “clarifying” in a :

1. The oracles gave Proclus a more concrete symbolic language to express the ineffable metaphysics of Plato.
2. By interpreting the oracles through his system, Proclus also —turning poetic revelation into conceptual philosophy.

So, the influence is rather than one-directional.
Proclus doesn’t *learn* metaphysics from the Chaldeans; he ,
and in interpreting them, .

In the wake of Spanu's work (and that of Harald Seng, Ruth Majercik, and others):

- Scholars now largely

  :

– that Proclus is simply imposing his philosophy on alien material;
– or that the oracles are the secret source of his system.

- The consensus is that

  : they gave Proclus language and imagery to *clarify, justify, and sacralize* his metaphysics.

- Thus,

  ,

  not foundational.

✳

Chaldean Oracles

Spanu's study establishes that their effect was not merely decorative: they offered Proclus a revelatory grammar through which the triadic logic of Neoplatonism could be expressed as a sacred cosmology.

Would you like me to make a follow-up table mapping

to the

and Spanu's notes on how each doctrine was shaped or clarified? That would serve as a companion map to the previous fragment table.

USER

has proclus left the ranch of the sort of austerity of plotinus's simplicity or is his ontology ultimately consonant with the roots of neoplatonism

ASSISTANT

That is one of the great interpretive questions about Proclus — whether he of the One–Intellect–Soul triad, or whether his elaborate metaphysics remains .

Scholars disagree on this point, but the best current view — including that of Nicola Spanu — is that , even as it their articulation. In other words, he doesn't leave the ranch; he

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Plotinus' metaphysics, especially in the *Enneads*, is characterized by

:

Absolute simplicity	Beyond being, self-sufficient, without multiplicity.
The realm of Forms	Unity-in-multiplicity; being and thought coincide.
Dynamic	Mediates between intelligible and sensible realms.

Plotinus insists that the One is *utterly transcendent* — to ascribe even "being" to it is already to speak too much. The metaphysical process of *emanation* is described apophatically:

This framework is deliberately minimal: it seeks to preserve — three principles suffice to explain all reality.

Proclus' metaphysics, especially as expressed in the *Elements of Theology* and the *Platonic Theology*, :

- Between the One and Being he introduces — divine unities corresponding to gods.

- Within Being he introduces (e.g. *Being–Life–Intellect*), each expressing the pattern of *remaining–procession–reversion*.

- Each level reflects , which Plotinus had only described qualitatively.

Yet, Proclus insists throughout that this

but

. The One remains simple; its

emanations are ordered manifestations of that simplicity.

As he writes in *ET* § 35–38:

> "In all things there is a triad: abiding, procession, and reversion. The first is the preservation of the cause, the second its power, the third the conversion of the effect to the cause."

These triads are but of participation. The apparent proliferation is a , not its fragmentation.

E.R. Dodds, L. Siorvanes	Proclus replaces Plotinus' mystical simplicity with scholastic structure; metaphysics becomes "metaphysical theology."

H. D. Saffrey, W. Beierwaltes, D. O'Meara, R. Chlup	The elaboration of triads and henads is implicit in Plotinus; Proclus simply makes explicit the logic of emanation and participation.
Nicola Spanu, Gregory Shaw, H. Seng	Proclus deepens the Neoplatonic vision by incorporating the *Chaldean Oracles* and theurgy, but the core remains Plotinian: all things proceed from and return to the One.

Spanu belongs to the last camp.
He sees Proclus as the Neoplatonic project by into an ontological framework that still rests on Plotinian principles of unity and procession.

> “Even where Proclus systematizes and ritualizes the One’s procession, he remains faithful to the Neoplatonic conviction that all multiplicity is the unfolding of unity and that return (epistrophē) completes being.” (*Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles*, ch. 5 summary)

Let’s look at the structural correspondences:

The One + Henads (divine unities)	The Henads are *participations* of the One’s unity, not rivals. Each is “one” by the One.
The intelligible triad *Being–Life–Intellect*	Proclus unpacks the internal logic of Nous into a triadic self-reflection; still Plotinian in essence.
Series of souls, daemons, and cosmic vehicles	Extension of Plotinus’ World-Soul; more hierarchical, not conceptually alien.
Triadic rhythm	Systematized version of Plotinus’

	(remaining–procession–reversion)	metaphors of overflow and return.
	Theurgy and symbolic reversion	Ritual embodiment of the same *epistrophē* Plotinus describes contemplatively.

Thus, while

, its

.

The break, if there is one, is not ontological but :

—	—
interior ascent of intellect to the ineffable.	cosmic and symbolic ascent through divine intermediaries.
— the One as silence beyond language.	— the One expressed through a hierarchy of causes.

Proclus' give his philosophy a that Plotinus avoided, but his metaphysical core remains the same: *all beings are united through participation in the One.*

In *Proclus and the Chaldean Oracles*, Spanu explicitly defends this continuity:

> "Proclus' exegesis of the Chaldean Oracles never departs from the Platonic foundations of his system. It rather gives symbolic density to a metaphysics whose essential structure—unity, procession, reversion—remains entirely within the Neoplatonic tradition." (ch. 5, §0.6)

He argues that Proclus' adoption of Chaldean symbolism

of metaphysical ascent without betraying its philosophical austerity.

- His many gods, henads, and triads articulate the inner logic of unity rather than replacing it.

- , but both describe the same movement from and toward the One.

- Thus, while , — and the edifice, however ornate, still stands on the same austere metaphysical ground.

Proclus has not “left the ranch.” He built fences, temples, and pathways across it, but the soil beneath — the conviction that

all multiplicity is the self-explication of the One — remains purely Neoplatonic.

USER

henads and plotinus

ASSISTANT

Excellent — this is a pivotal topic for understanding both the of Proclus within the Neoplatonic lineage. The are often seen as Proclus's most original metaphysical invention, and their relation to reveals precisely how he elaborates the tradition without abandoning its foundations.

Let's unpack this in steps, showing (1) what henads are, (2) what Plotinus lacks or only hints at, and (3) how later Neoplatonists (especially Proclus) introduce them as a

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In Proclus, *henads* (ἑνάδες, “unities”) are

, yet are

.

- Each henad is a *god*, a unique divine unity.
- The One transcends them all; they are its immediate emanations.
- The henads are — they stand above *Being* and *Intellect* but below the *One-itself*.
- They are *“ones that are not the One,”* divine participations in unity before multiplicity divides into intelligible and sensible orders.

Thus, the metaphysical sequence becomes:

→

→

The henads

.

They prevent a direct leap from absolute simplicity to structured multiplicity by introducing a layer of *divine singularities* — the many “ones” through which the One’s unity is distributed without being divided.

Plotinus (204–270 CE) never uses the term *henads*, but he
or *unities* derived from the One:

Ennead VI.9 [9] 5–8	The One is beyond being, cause of all unity.	Absolute transcendence; nothing stands "between" the One and Nous.
Enn. VI.7 [38] 15	Each being is one "in virtue of" the One.	Suggests participation in unity but not independent henads.
Enn. V.1 [10] 6	"Everything that exists is one and many."	Implies the *presence of unity in all things* but not hypostatized unities.
Enn. VI.9 [9] 5–6	The gods of the ancients symbolize	Mythic prefiguration of

aspects of the One's power. what Proclus will make explicit.

So: Plotinus speaks of *"the presence of the One in all things"* (ἡ τοῦ ἑνὸς παρουσία), but for him this presence is

— the One is not multiplied. There are

mediating between the One and Intellect; the leap from transcendence to intelligibility is immediate.

Post-Plotinian thinkers — notably , then — found this leap too abrupt.

They faced a theological and metaphysical tension:

> How can the ineffable One cause a rich, hierarchical cosmos ?

The solution: posit (henads) that are:

- , to account for the plurality of divine orders;
- , because each is a perfect participation in the One's unity;
- , because they are beyond being and thought (not "beings" but "unities").

Thus, —an expression of the One's unity, distinct but not divided.
The Greek gods, as Proclus reads them, are metaphysical unities — whose causal activity generates their specific "series" (*seirai*) throughout the cosmos.

Proclus' reasoning (see *Elements of Theology* §§113–120):

1.

→ Therefore, unity must be prior to being.

2.

→ But participation requires intermediaries; there must be *participated ones* below the One-itself.

3.

— each of which *is one* by participation in the One.

→ These are the *henads*.

In this way, the henads are a

for preserving Plotinus's principle that all things exist "by unity" while also allowing a diversity of divine causation.

The One beyond being.	The same ineffable One beyond being.
Nous (Intellect).	Henads (divine unities) precede Nous.
None; procession is direct.	Henads mediate the procession through multiple divine causes.
Symbolic or poetic only.	Ontologically real; each god = a henad.
All things one “by participation in the One.”	All things one “through their proper henad” (their divine unity).

	Total, leaving only presence as trace.	Same transcendence, but expressed through many unities that safeguard its causality.

So, Proclus preserves Plotinus' One but that makes the divine multiplicity *ontologically legitimate* instead of merely symbolic.

Not really — it’s a

.

- For Plotinus, the One’s causal power is immediate and undifferentiated.

- For Proclus, that immediacy risks collapsing divine plurality into abstraction.

- The henads

while

.

As W. Beierwaltes put it:

> “Proclus does not multiply unity; he unfolds its inner fecundity.” (*Proklos. Grundzüge seiner Metaphysik*, 1965)

Nicola Spanu echoes this judgment, noting that the henads are “

— a conceptual translation of the Oracles' gods into metaphysical unities."

Spanu's reading (2021):

- The *Chaldean Oracles* speak of many divine *Fathers*, *Powers*, and *Intellects* — a .
- Proclus adopts this symbolic polytheism and as henads.
- Thus, the henadic level reconciles:

- Plotinus' , and
- the of Iamblichus and the Chaldeans.

In this sense, the henads are Proclus's way of keeping while acknowledging of late antiquity.

One	One + many henads
Direct, ineffable cause of all	Mediated through divine unities
Presence of the One	Participation through proper henad
Implicit monotheism	Explicit polytheistic hierarchy
Mystical union with the One	Theurgic and contemplative union through the gods (henads)
Foundational	Elaborative — same roots, richer articulation

✳️

The henads do not replace the One — they

.

Proclus’ move thus

, remaining ontologically consonant with the roots of Neoplatonism while giving it the metaphysical architecture needed to sustain both philosophical rigor and religious richness.